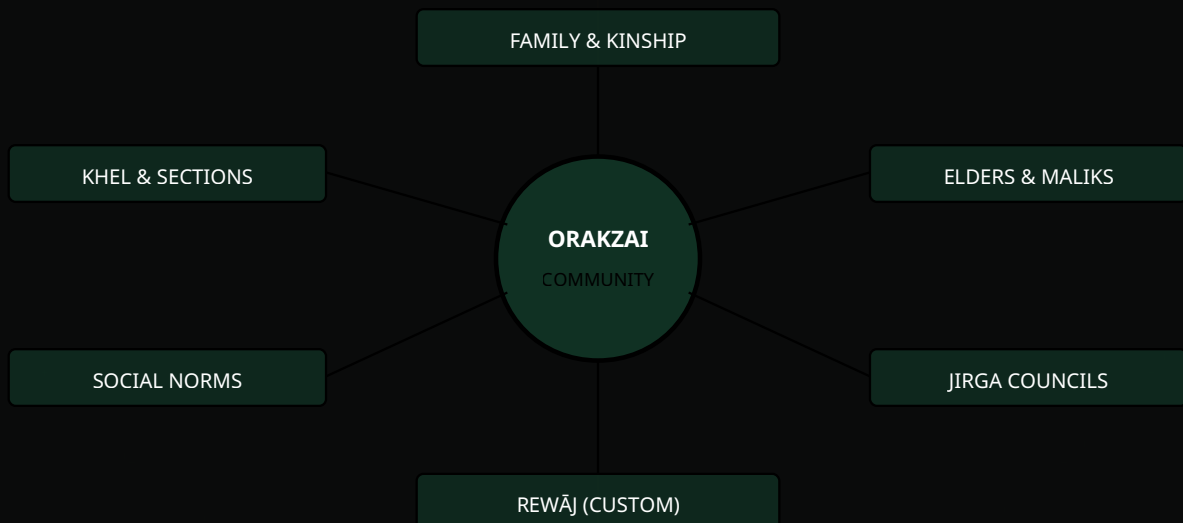


TRADITIONAL ORAKZAI GOVERNANCE

“Decentralized authority, customary order, and the organization of collective life.”

Before modern administrative institutions reached deep into the tribal areas, communities still needed ways to organize everyday life. They needed to settle disagreements, protect relationships, negotiate with neighboring communities, respond collectively to threats, and decide who could speak on behalf of the community.

Among the Orakzai, these functions were not concentrated in a single central government. They were distributed through a network of families, kinship groups, elders, representatives, jirgas, customary practices, and community relationships. This was traditional governance.¹²



“Traditional governance emerged through relationships, customary practice, and collective institutions.”

GOVERNANCE VS. GOVERNMENT

It is crucial to distinguish between governance and formal government. Government refers specifically to centralized state institutions, whereas governance encompasses the broader mechanisms by which a society organizes authority, resolves disputes, maintains cooperation, and ensures collective security. Traditional Orakzai society operated without a centralized state apparatus, relying instead on decentralized customary structures.³⁴

GOVERNMENT

- Centralized State Bureaucracy
- Written Constitutions
- Statutory Courts & Police
- Formal Taxation & Law

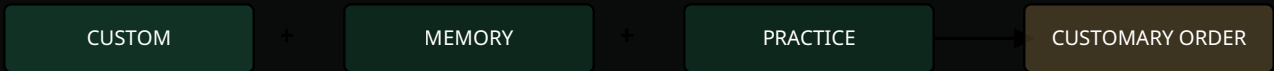
GOVERNANCE

- Decentralized Customary Order
- Kinship & Social Norms
- Elders, Maliks & Jirga
- Community Trust & Reciprocity

“Different modalities of organizing collective life.”

REWĀR AND CUSTOMARY ORDER

Traditional governance relied heavily on **Rewāj** (customary practice) and the broader cultural framework of **Pashtunwali**. *Rewāj* was not a codified legal book, but a flexible, memory-based system of norms, precedents, and community expectations that regulated land use, inheritance, dispute resolution, and social responsibilities.³



“Analytical model of Rewāj—customary order through shared memory and social acceptance.”

HISTORICAL TRANSFORMATION AND MODERN INTEGRATION

The administrative status of the Orakzai region underwent profound changes, from pre-colonial customary autonomy to British frontier administration, the establishment of the FATA system, and finally the historic ****25th Constitutional Amendment in 2018****, which merged the tribal areas into Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and brought them under mainstream constitutional governance.⁴



“Evolution of Orakzai governance from customary autonomy to modern constitutional integration.”

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

Traditional governance interests me because it shows that people do not wait for institutions to become formal before they begin organizing society. Long before modern databases, courts, digital networks, and government platforms, communities had their own ways of remembering

obligations, resolving disputes, and making collective decisions. But tradition should not be frozen in time. The Orakzai of the future will live in a world of constitutional law, universities, technology, artificial intelligence, global business, and digital communities. The question is not whether tradition should replace modernity, but what we should preserve, what we should improve, and what we should leave behind.

“Tradition is not a prison. It is a foundation when we know how to build upon it.”

AUTHOR'S SYNTHESIS
